Cometh the Hour

Once he overcame his initial hesitance, the Soviet leader received Ulbricht and Honecker in the Kremlin on 11 April 1971 during the XXIV Party Congress.

Coming quickly to the point, Ulbricht was told to resign as First Secretary, but to relieve his dismay, he would keep the position of Chairman of the State Council and become honorary chairman of the SED, a ceremonial post created to guarantee fraternal amity. Honecker, he was told, was his anointed successor. Wearily, after swallowing this fresh humiliation, Ulbricht left the room.

According to the memoirs of Markus Wolf, the saga didn't end there. Several days later, presumably worried that the old man would continue to exert political influence or even stage a counter-coup, Honecker added intimidation to his lengthening list of antics by turning up at Ulbricht's holiday home seeking to ensure his old mentor would step down (he arrived, according to Wolf, with armed security forces and even cut the telephone lines). After a hot exchange, Ulbricht lost his nerve. Thinking Honecker unstable, unprincipled and unsound, he grudgingly gave way and promised his resignation in writing. (Exact details are not recorded but the conversation allegedly lasted ninety minutes).

In the end, Ulbricht hung on to his office until 3 May when, with ritual insincerity, he chaired his last full meeting of the Politburo. Tired, and possibly still in a state of shock, he mumbled that the years had 'left their marks' and did not allow him to continue such strenuous work: 'I therefore, think the time has come to place these functions into younger hands and I propose to elect comrade Erich Honecker as the new secretary of the Central Committee.'1

In a bulletin flashed by ADN, Honecker spoke of the heavy responsibility he had inherited and assured he would 'not spare any strength to prove